

JSS 2 NIGERIAN HISTORY – FIRST TERM

TOPIC 1: INDEPENDENCE OF NIGERIA

1. Events of 1 October 1960

On 1 October 1960, Nigeria gained independence from British colonial rule. The Union Jack was lowered and the Nigerian green-white-green flag was raised at the Racecourse (now Tafawa Balewa Square) in Lagos. Princess Alexandra of Kent represented Queen Elizabeth II. The independence constitution provided for a parliamentary system within the Commonwealth.

2. Prime Minister and Governor-General

- **Prime Minister:** Alhaji Sir Abubakar Tafawa Balewa (leader of government business).
- **Governor-General:** Dr Nnamdi Azikiwe (representing the Queen as head of state until Nigeria became a republic in 1963).

Regional Premiers included: Northern Region – Sir Ahmadu Bello (Sardauna of Sokoto); Western Region – Chief Obafemi Awolowo (later others); Eastern Region – Dr Michael Okpara.

3. Significance

Independence ended formal British political control and gave Nigerians responsibility for their own government. It was the result of long nationalist struggles by parties and leaders across the country.

4. Summary

Nigeria became independent on 1 October 1960 with Tafawa Balewa as Prime Minister and Nnamdi Azikiwe as Governor-General. The day marked the birth of a sovereign Nigerian state.

End of Topic 1